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Building Secure RAG

Enforcing Data Governance with Azure AI Search and Purview Sensitivity Labels

March 17, 2026

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About me | Tech

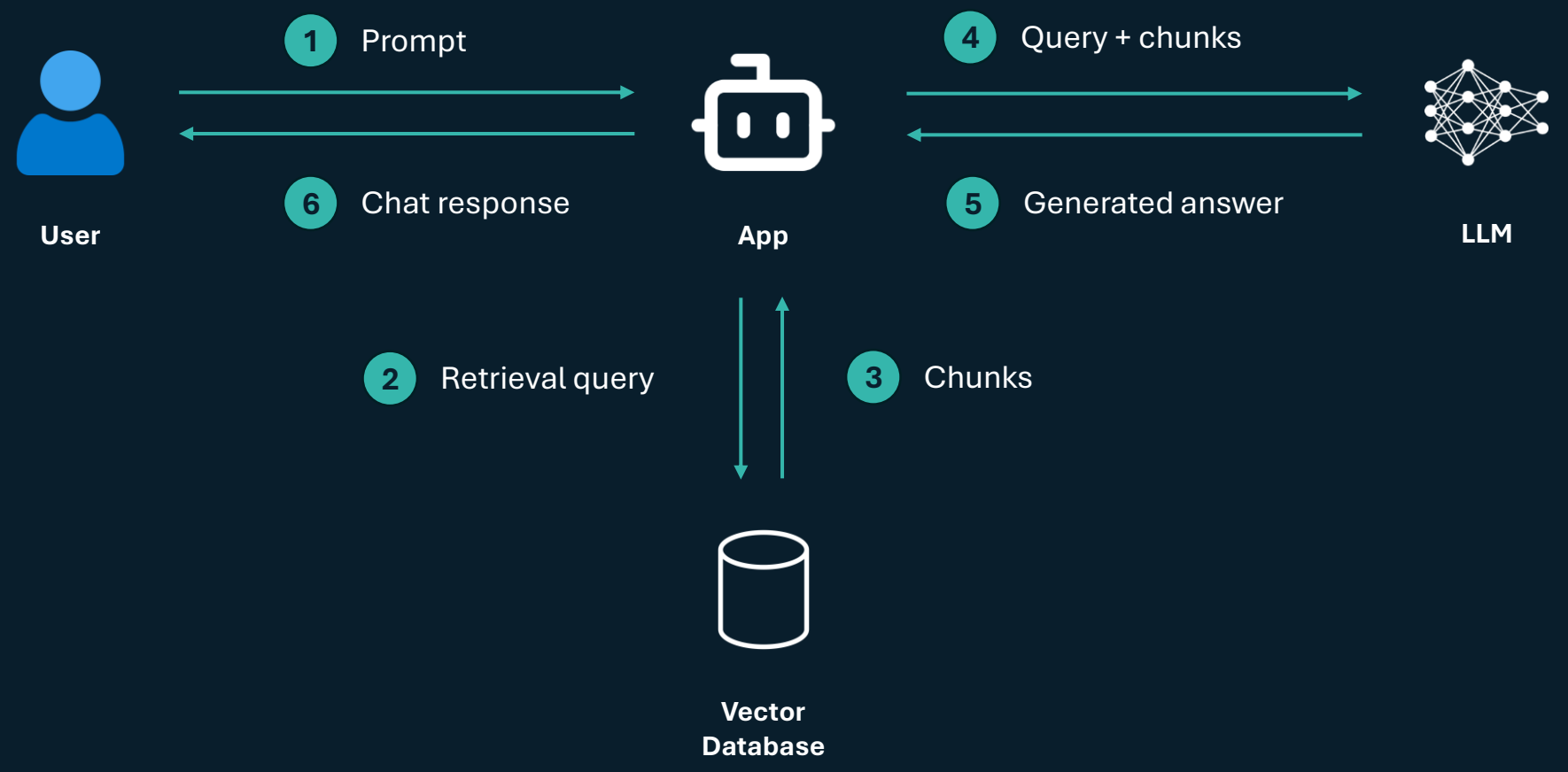
Azure Architecture, AI, Automation, Security

About me | Private

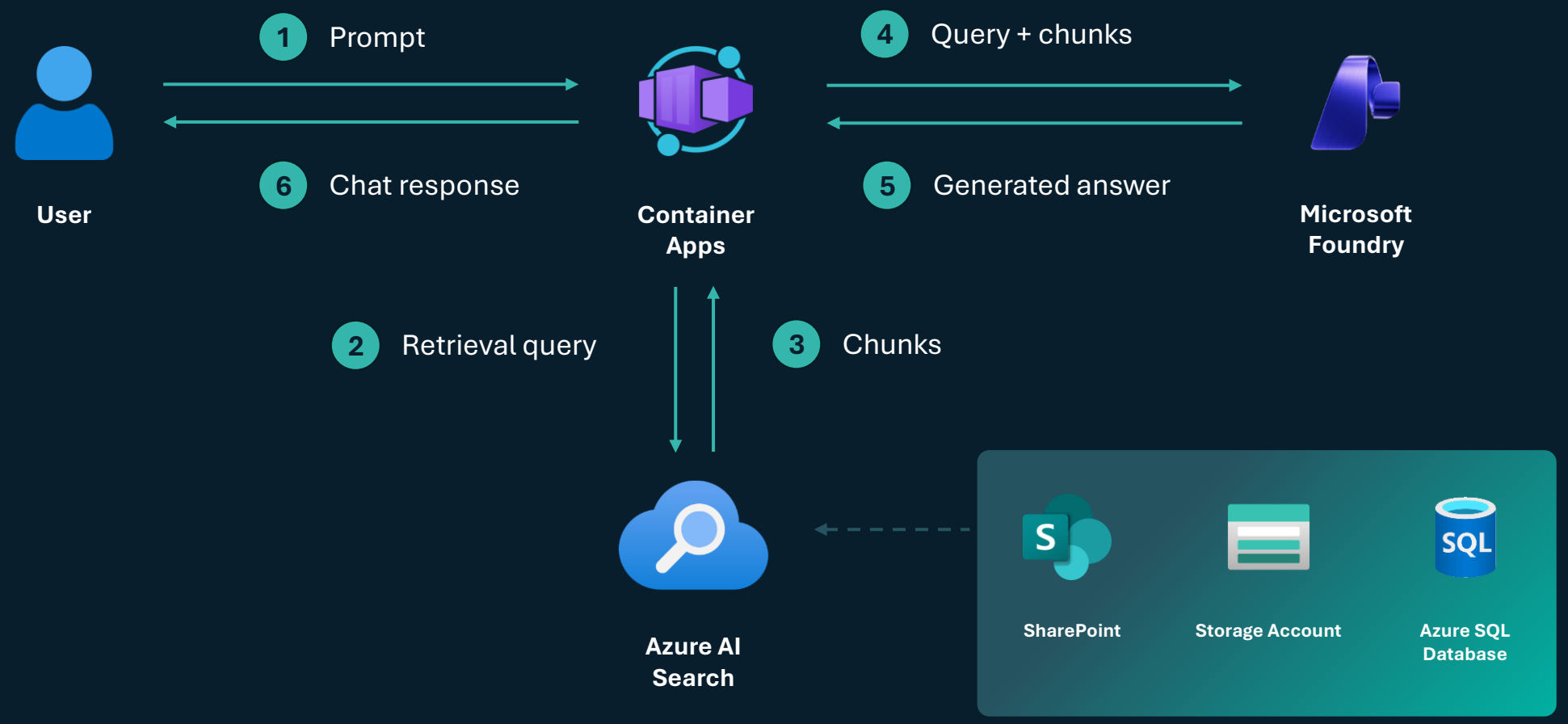
Winterthur, Alpine sports, Photography, Travel

MODELS
AGENTS
RAG
CHAT BOTS
COPILOTS
TOKENS
AUTONOMOUS

Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)



Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)

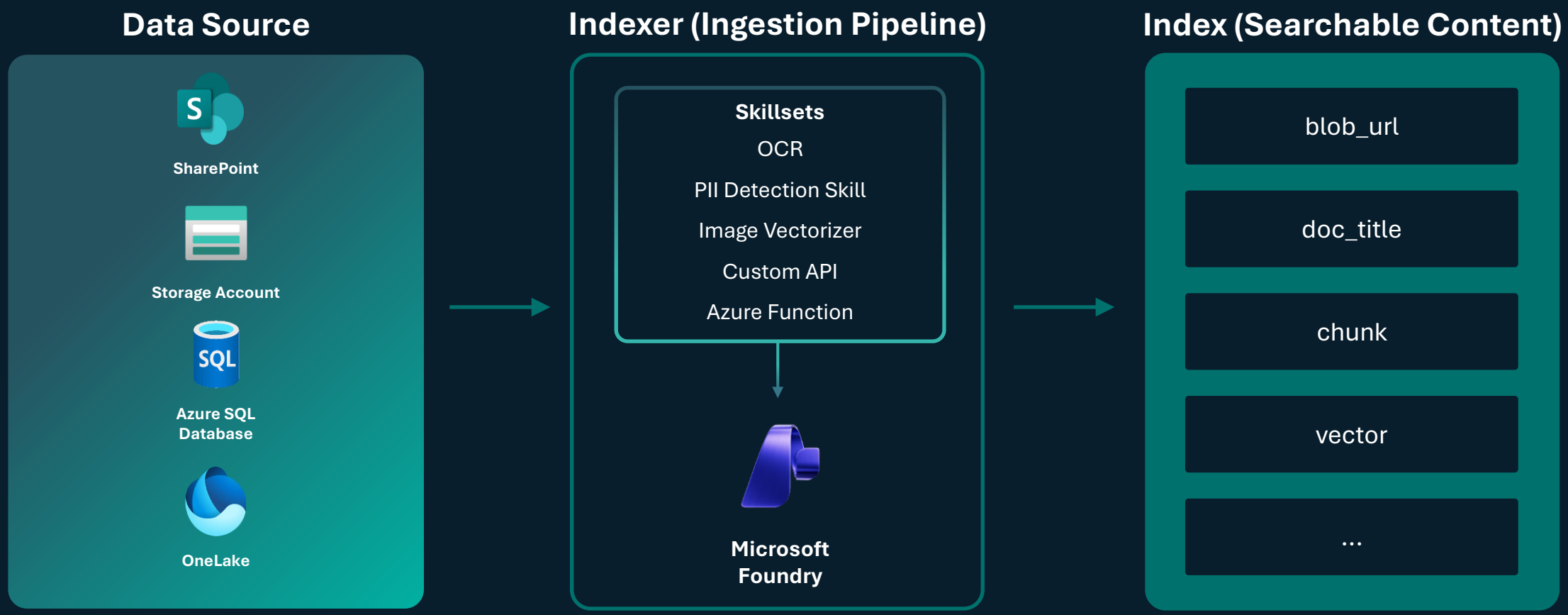


Azure AI Search

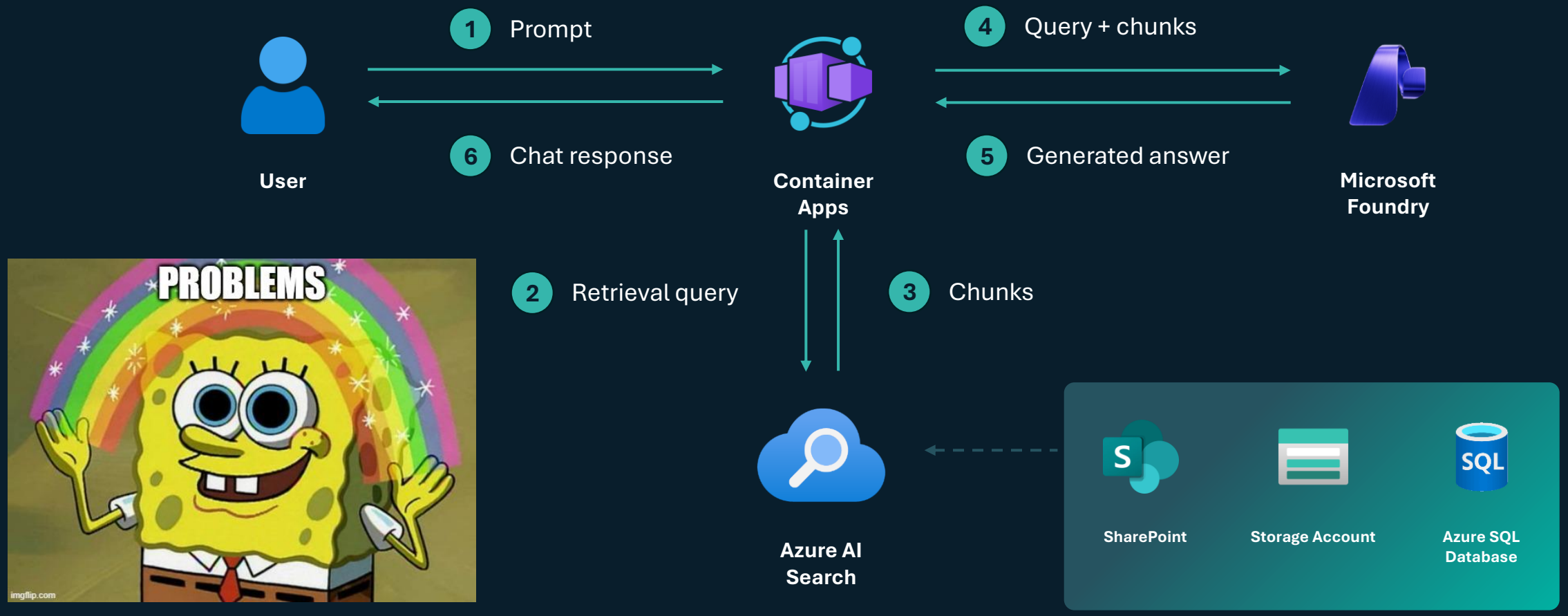
Azure AI Search

- Enterprise retrieval and search engine
- Azure PaaS service
- Full-text, vector, hybrid and multimodal
- Data-ingestion pipelines (indexers)
- Classic and agentic retrieval (Foundry IQ)
- Integration in most Microsoft AI products

Indexing


Data Source
SharePoint
Storage Account
Azure SQL Database
OneLake
Indexer (Ingestion Pipeline)
Skillsets
OCR
PII Detection Skill
Image Vectorizer
Custom API
Azure Function
Microsoft Foundry
Index (Searchable Content)
blob_url
doc_title
chunk
vector
...

Traditional RAG



Azure
AI Search
Purview
sensitivity labels
imgflip.com

Microsoft Purview

Microsoft Purview

Discover, classify, manage, protect

Data security

- Data Loss Prevention
- Data Security Investigations
- Information Barriers
- Information Protection
- Insider Risk Management
- Privileged Access Management

Data Governance

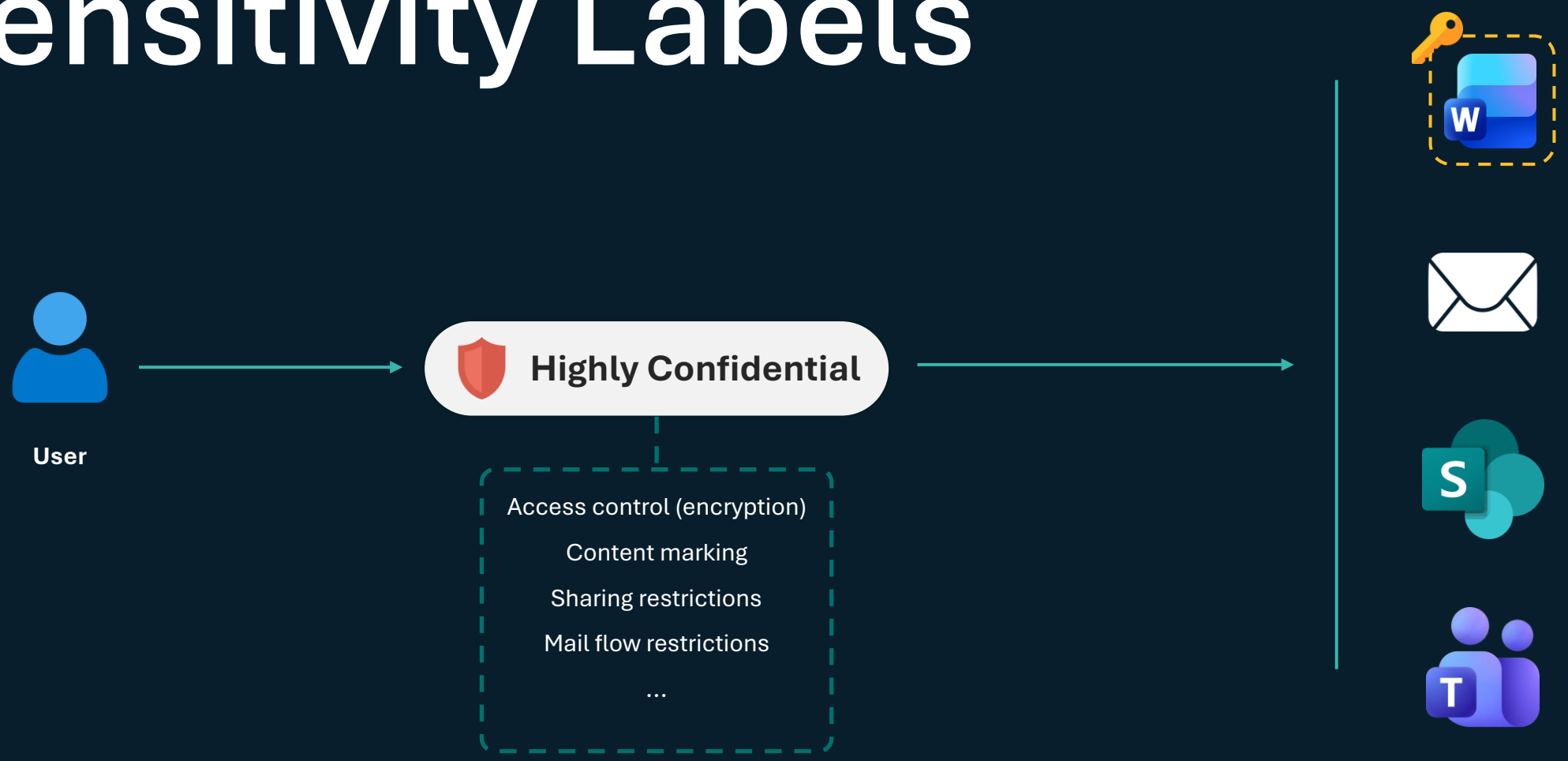
- Data Map
- Unified Catalog

Data Compliance

- Compliance Manager
- Data Lifecycle Management
- eDiscovery
- Records Management
- Communication Compliance

Sensitivity Labels

Sensitivity Labels



Let’s take a look

Azure AI Search and Sensitivity Labels

Document-level security

Current capabilities:

Security filters

PREVIEW

POSIX ACL and RBAC scopes

Azure Blob, Azure Data Lake Storage Gen2

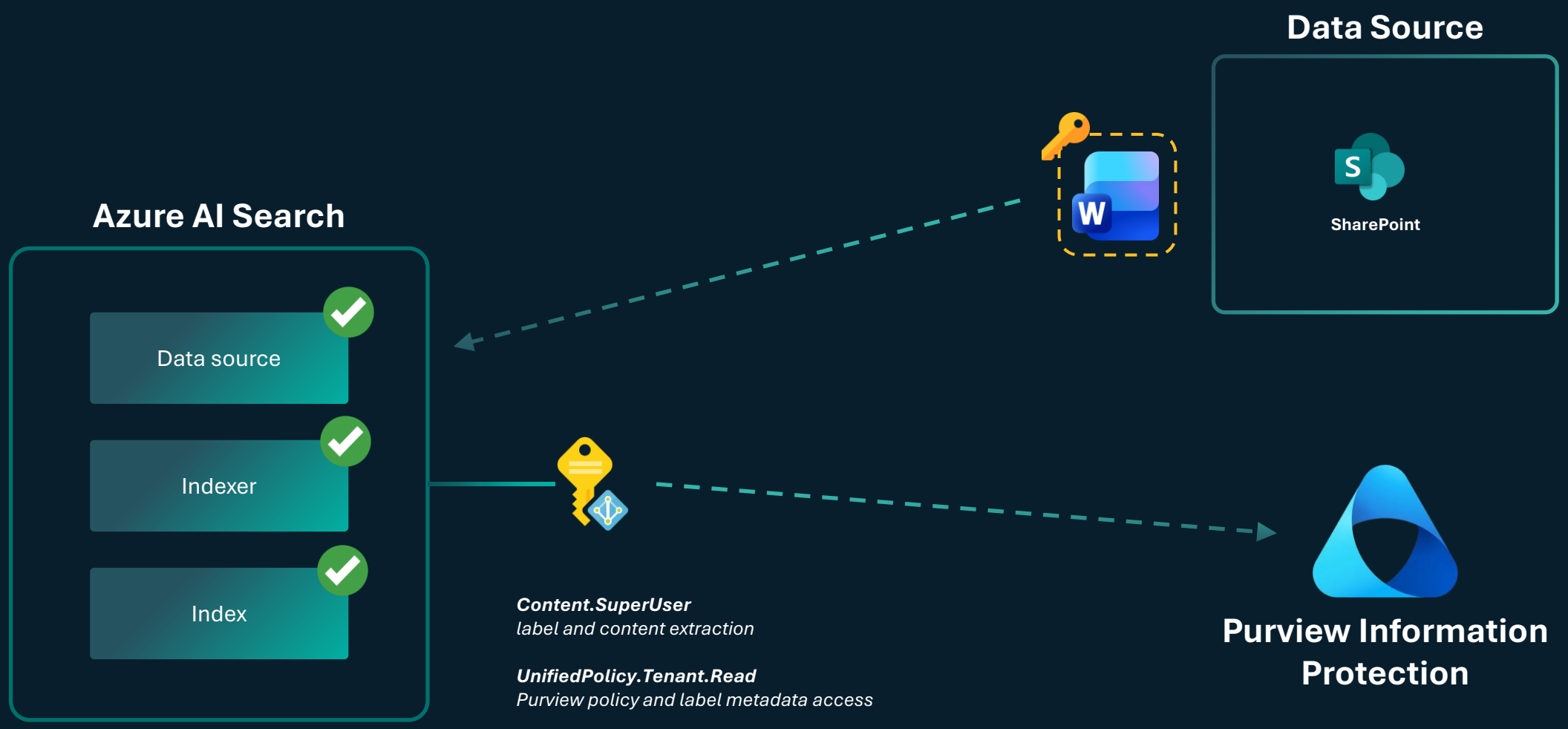
PREVIEW

Microsoft Purview Sensitivity Labels

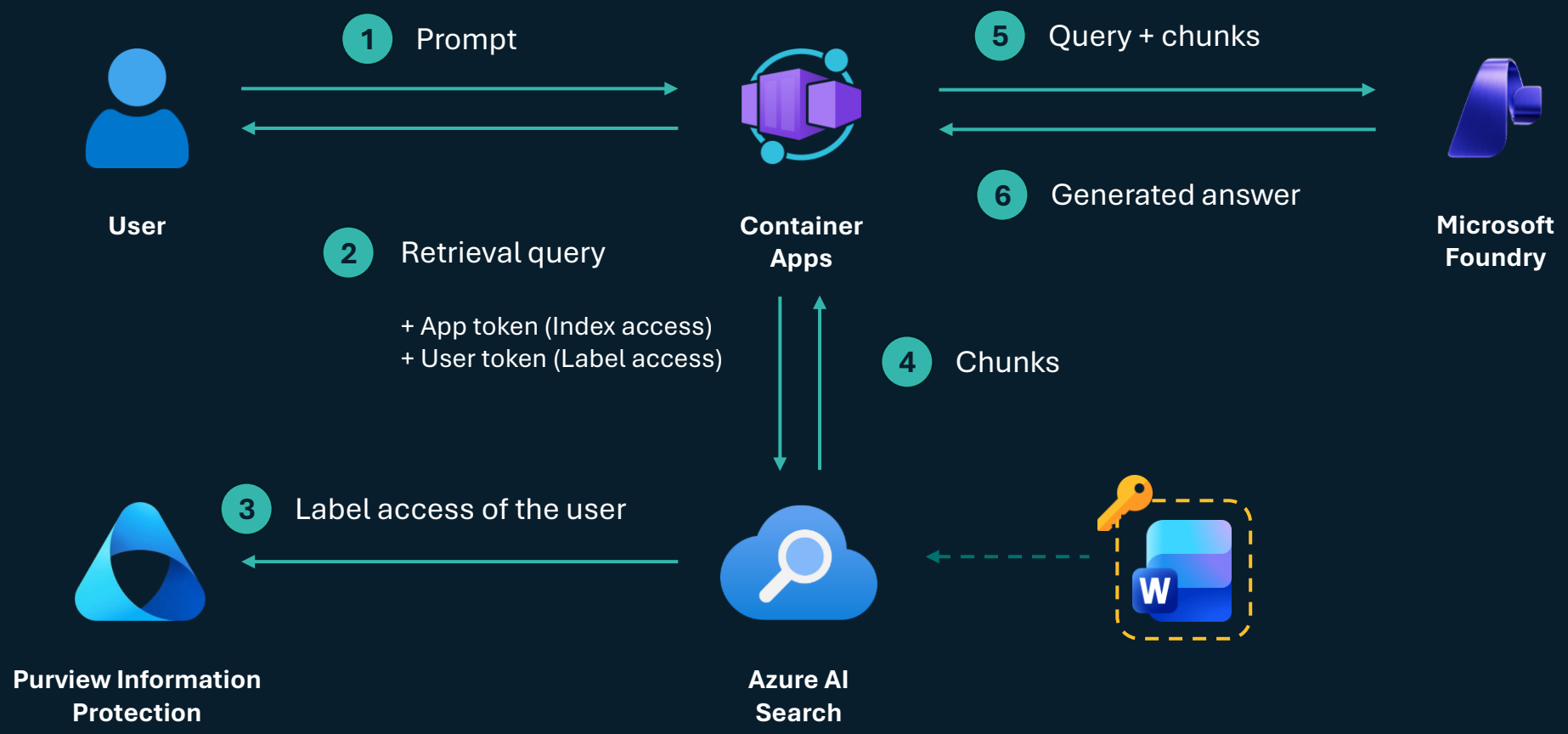
PREVIEW

SharePoint Online ACL

Indexing labeled documents



Query-time access enforcement



Let’s go hands-on

… or not

The documents are:

1. Project_Orion_Internal_Preview.docx: A technical brief on Project Orion, ZAVA's AI-powered routing engine, including product vision, system architecture, benchmarks, integration roadmap, risk mitigation, sprint milestones, ethical AI, and links to design docs and repos.
2. Support_Readiness_Guide_Project_Orion_Pilot.docx: A support guide for the Orion pilot, covering capabilities, troubleshooting, escalation paths, telemetry setup, FAQs, talking points, readiness checklist, feedback form, and pilot support channel link.
3. ZAVA_Remote_Work_Guidelines_FY26_Update.docx: An HR policy update on ZAVA's hybrid work model, including work schedule, equipment reimbursement, team syncs, remote readiness checklist, FAQs, remote culture tips, HR contacts, escalation paths, and training links.

[1] [2] [3]

RESPONSE SENSITIVITY LABEL

Confidential\All Employees

Citation:

1. Project_Orion_Internal_Preview.docx — Confidential\All Employees
2. Support_Readiness_Guide_Project_Orion_Pilot.docx — General\All Employees (unrestricted)
3. ZAVA_Remote_Work_Guidelines_FY26_Update.docx — Confidential\All Employees

Type a new question (e.g. does my plan cover annual eye exams?)

Key Takeaways

- Opens up to new use cases in Enterprise RAG
- Preview territory
  - Lacking documentation
  - Not portal support
  - Many limitations
- Limited visibility due to label access control
- `Content.Superuser` permission necessary
- PATIENCE
- Development efforts necessary
  - Parsing label names
  - Constructing the correct headers

Thank you!

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